MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 2: Learning Theories

ENGLISH LANGUAGE TEACHING • M21EG01AC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Learning theories explain different aspects of language development and help teachers design, observe, and revise instruction.

Start with a picture

One learner improves through repeated practice, another needs to see a pattern, and a pair solve a problem by helping each other. These situations suggest different questions, but they do not prove that each learner belongs permanently to one type.

1. Behaviourism

Behaviourist accounts emphasise observable behaviour, environmental conditions, practice, and consequences. Pavlov’s classical conditioning and Skinner’s operant conditioning are related but distinct traditions. **Reinforcement** increases a behaviour; **punishment** aims to reduce it.

Negative reinforcement is not the same as punishment: removing an unpleasant condition can reinforce a response. Do not use the word negative to mean every unwanted teaching practice.

In language teaching, imitation, patterned drills, and immediate feedback can develop fluency with a limited form. Their limitation is that language users also create utterances they have never copied.

2. Cognitivism

Cognitive approaches attend to attention, memory, pattern recognition, mental representation, and problem solving. Learners are not only responding to a stimulus; they interpret and organise information.

A teacher might compare several sentences, ask learners to infer a pattern, and then test it on a new example. Chunking information and connecting it with prior knowledge can reduce unnecessary processing demands.

Bloom’s taxonomy helps vary cognitive demands. The original version includes knowledge, comprehension, application, analysis, synthesis, and evaluation; the revised version uses remember, understand, apply, analyse, evaluate, and create. Neither taxonomy proves a rigid developmental timetable for every learner.

3. Chomsky and generative language

Chomsky challenges the adequacy of habit alone to explain creative language use. Generative accounts investigate the internal knowledge that allows speakers to produce and understand new sentences.

Universal Grammar is a theoretical proposal about constraints or capacities involved in human language. The **Language Acquisition Device** is a conceptual model, not a small physical organ that a teacher can point to. The theories and their application to additional-language learning remain debated.

Distinguish competence, an account of linguistic knowledge, from performance under actual conditions such as memory limits or distraction.

4. Piaget and cognitive constructivism

Learners actively organise experience through developing structures. **Assimilation** fits new experience within an existing schema; **accommodation** changes the schema when it is inadequate.

A child who calls every animal a dog may revise the category after comparison. Classroom use should build on prior understanding and create opportunities for revision. Do not apply stage labels as inflexible limits on every child’s capability.

5. Vygotsky and social constructivism

Interaction, language, and cultural tools help mediate development. The **zone of proximal development** concerns what a learner can achieve with appropriate assistance beyond current independent performance.

Scaffolding provides temporary support—prompts, models, partial steps, or collaboration—and adjusts it as competence grows. The term was developed later within work influenced by this tradition, including Bruner; it is not simply another name Vygotsky gave to every kind of help.

6. A classroom comparison

Objective: use a past-tense account of an event.

- Behaviourist emphasis: model and practise a useful pattern with corrective feedback.
- Cognitive emphasis: compare examples and identify a rule or contrast.
- Constructivist emphasis: build on existing accounts, test interpretations, and revise them.
- Social emphasis: pairs jointly tell a story with temporary prompts, then repeat more independently.

A teacher can combine these resources purposefully rather than declare one total theory victorious.

Quick check

1. Is all practice behaviourism? **No; the theory involves a fuller account of learning.**
2. Is LAD an identified classroom-visible organ? **No.**
3. Should scaffolding remain unchanged forever? **No; support should respond to growing independence.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define the theories' different explanatory focuses.
2. Compare teacher and learner roles.
3. Use one shared language objective for examples.
4. Explain competing interpretations of error.
5. Evaluate the limits of turning a theory into a recipe.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not confuse negative reinforcement with punishment, describe innate-language proposals as settled physical facts, or assign students permanently to fixed theoretical types.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare how learning theories affect the teacher's role, classroom activity, and interpretation of error.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Learning theories differ in what they treat as the main mechanism of change. A behaviourist emphasis directs attention to practice, feedback, and the conditions that strengthen a response. Cognitive accounts make interpretation and mental organisation central. Constructivist and sociocultural perspectives add the learner's active revision of understanding and the role of interaction and cultural tools.

These differences affect a lesson without requiring separate permanent categories of student. In a past-tense task, a teacher can model a form, invite comparison among examples, and organise a supported retelling. The components need to serve the same objective. Simply mixing activities without explaining their purpose is not informed eclecticism.

Error is a particularly useful test. An incorrect response may indicate insufficient practice, a processing difficulty, an overgeneralised rule, or a need for more effective support. One observation does not establish which explanation is correct. The teacher can vary the task, examine patterns across attempts, and use the result to revise instruction.

The theories should consequently be presented as explanatory resources rather than complete recipes. Chomsky's account of linguistic creativity challenges a narrow habit model, but it does not by itself specify a full classroom method. A strong answer defines the concepts, illustrates their pedagogical implications, and evaluates the limits of the inference

from theory to teaching.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. "Behaviourists consider learning a language as a set of mechanical habits which are formed through a process of imitation and repetition". Illustrate.
2. Compare and contrast the role of the teacher in a Behaviourist and Constructivist classroom.
3. List down the stages of teaching the following lines of a poem by Wordsworth. You may follow either the Behaviourist approach or Constructivist approach but specify the classroom activity, the role of the teacher and the learner. "My Heart Leaps Up" My heart leaps up when I behold A rainbow in the sky: So was it when my life began; So is it now I am a man; So be it when I shall grow old, Or let me die! The Child is father of the Man; And I could wish my days to be Bound each to each by natural piety.
4. "Noam Chomsky used his theories within syntax to arrive at the revolutionary idea that all humans are born with an innate ability to learn languages"- Explain.
5. Explain the theory of behaviourism.
6. Describe the theory of cognitivism.
7. Elucidate the theory of constructivism.
8. What is Universal Grammar?
9. Explain Language Acquisition Device.